Power-sharing

The big idea

In a democracy, **power is not concentrated in one person, group or organ of government**. It is shared among different organs, levels, social groups and parties. This chapter uses two stories, **Belgium** and **Sri Lanka**, to show why sharing power keeps a country united, and why refusing to share can tear it apart.

Belgium: accommodation

Belgium is a small country in Europe, smaller in area than the state of Haryana, with a population of a little over one crore.

Group	Share of population	Region
Dutch-speaking	**59%**	Flemish region
French-speaking	**40%**	Wallonia region
German-speaking	**1%**	

In the capital, **Brussels**, **80%** speak French and **20%** speak Dutch. The minority French-speaking community was relatively rich and powerful. This was resented by the Dutch-speaking community, who got the benefit of economic development and education much later. This led to tensions in the 1950s and 1960s, more acute in Brussels, where Dutch speakers were a majority in the country but a minority in the capital.

THE BELGIAN MODEL OF ACCOMMODATION

Between **1970 and 1993**, Belgian leaders **amended their constitution four times**, working out an innovative arrangement:

1. The Constitution prescribes that the number of **Dutch and French-speaking ministers shall be equal** in the central government. Some special laws require support of the majority of members from each linguistic group, so no single community can make decisions unilaterally.
2. Many powers of the central government have been given to **state governments** of the two regions. State governments are **not subordinate** to the central government.
3. **Brussels has a separate government** in which both communities have **equal representation**. The French-speaking people accepted equal representation in Brussels because the Dutch-speaking community accepted equal representation in the central government.
4. Apart from central and state governments, there is a third kind of government, the **'community government'**, elected by people belonging to one language community (Dutch, French or German), no matter where they live. It has power regarding **cultural, educational and language-related issues**.

The arrangement is complicated, but it has worked well: it helped avoid civic strife and a possible division of the country on linguistic lines. When many countries of Europe came together to form the **European Union**, **Brussels was chosen as its headquarters**.

Sri Lanka: majoritarianism

Sri Lanka, an island nation just off the southern coast of Tamil Nadu, has about 2 crore people.

- **Sinhala**-speakers: **74%**; **Tamil**-speakers: **18%**. Among Tamils, **Sri Lankan Tamils** (natives of the country) are **13%**, and **Indian Tamils** (whose forefathers came from India as plantation workers during colonial rule) are **5%**.
- Most Sinhala-speakers are **Buddhists**; most Tamils are **Hindus or Muslims**. About **7%** are Christians, both Tamil and Sinhala.
- Sri Lankan Tamils are concentrated in the **north and east** of the country.

MAJORITARIAN MEASURES AFTER INDEPENDENCE (1948)

Sri Lanka became independent in **1948**. Leaders of the Sinhala community sought to secure dominance by virtue of their majority. They adopted **majoritarian** measures:

- In **1956**, an Act was passed to recognise **Sinhala as the only official language**, disregarding Tamil.
- Governments followed preferential policies that **favoured Sinhala applicants for university positions and government jobs**.
- The new constitution stipulated that the state shall **protect and foster Buddhism**.

These measures gradually increased the feeling of alienation among Sri Lankan Tamils. They felt that none of the major political parties led by Buddhist Sinhala leaders was sensitive to their language and culture, and that the constitution and government policies denied them equal political rights, discriminated against them in getting jobs and other opportunities, and ignored their interests.

By the 1980s, several political organisations were formed demanding an **independent Tamil Eelam** (state) in northern and eastern Sri Lanka. The distrust turned into widespread conflict and soon a **civil war**. Thousands of people of both communities were killed; many families were forced to leave as refugees, and many more lost their livelihoods. The civil war ended in **2009** (with the defeat of the LTTE), but it caused a terrible setback to the social, cultural and economic life of the country.

MAJORITARIANISM

A belief that the **majority community should be able to rule a country in whichever way it wants**, by disregarding the wishes and needs of the minority.

Why power-sharing is desirable

TWO SETS OF REASONS

Prudential reasons (based on careful calculation of gains and losses): power-sharing is good because it helps to **reduce the possibility of conflict** between social groups. Since social conflict often leads to violence and political instability, power-sharing is a good way to **ensure the stability of political order**. Imposing the will of the majority community on others may look like an attractive option in the short run, but in the long run it undermines the unity of the nation (Sri Lanka shows this).

Moral reasons (based on the intrinsic worth of power-sharing): power-sharing is **the very spirit of democracy**. A democratic rule involves sharing power with those affected by its exercise and who have to live with its effects. People have a right to be consulted on how they are to be governed. A **legitimate government** is one where citizens, through participation, acquire a stake in the system.

Forms of power-sharing

1. **Horizontal distribution (among organs of government)**: power is shared among the **legislature, executive and judiciary**. Each organ is placed at the same level and **checks** the others. Ministers and government officials exercise power but are responsible to Parliament or State Assemblies; judges are appointed by the executive but can check the functioning of the executive or laws made by legislatures. This arrangement is called a system of **checks and balances**.
2. **Vertical distribution (among governments at different levels)**: a general government for the entire country (the **Union or Central Government**), governments at the provincial or regional level (**State Governments** in India), and further at the local level (**municipalities and panchayats**). Such a division of powers between higher and lower levels of government is called **vertical division of power**. When the Constitution clearly lays this down, it is **federal** government.

3. **Among social groups**: power may be shared among different social groups, such as religious and linguistic groups. The **'community government'** in Belgium is a good example. In some countries there are constitutional and legal arrangements whereby socially weaker sections and women are represented in legislatures and administration, like **reserved constituencies** in India.
4. **Among political parties, pressure groups and movements**: democracy ensures that power does not remain in the hands of one; competition among parties ensures power keeps shifting. In the long run, power is shared among different parties representing different ideologies and social groups. Sometimes two or more parties form an **alliance** to contest elections and, if elected, form a **coalition government**. Interest groups such as traders, businessmen, industrialists, farmers and industrial workers also share governmental power, either through participation in government committees or by influencing decision-making.

"POWER-SHARING WEAKENS A COUNTRY"

Many people think concentrated power gives quick decisions and unity. Belgium shows the opposite: sharing power **kept the country united**. Sri Lanka shows that refusing to share power **led to civil war**.

BOARD FAVOURITES

"Compare the Belgian and Sri Lankan approaches" (5 marks), "List the majoritarian measures adopted in Sri Lanka", "Explain the prudential and moral reasons for power-sharing", "Describe the forms of power-sharing with examples", "What are checks and balances?". Remember the population percentages for both countries.

Quick recap

- Belgium: Dutch 59%, French 40%, German 1%; Brussels 80% French, 20% Dutch.

- Belgian constitution amended four times (1970–1993): equal ministers, state governments, Brussels government, community government.
- Sri Lanka: Sinhala 74%, Tamils 18%; 1956 Act made Sinhala the only official language; civil war ended 2009.
- Prudential reasons: reduce conflict, ensure stability. Moral reasons: spirit of democracy, legitimacy.
- Forms: horizontal, vertical, among social groups, among parties/pressure groups.

Practice questions

1. In Belgium, the share of Dutch-speaking people in the population is
   (a) 40% (b) 59% (c) 80% (d) 74%
2. Which of these is NOT a feature of the Belgian model of power-sharing?
   (a) Equal number of Dutch and French ministers in the central government (b) A separate government for Brussels with equal representation (c) A community government elected by each language group (d) Making Dutch the only official language
3. The 1956 Act in Sri Lanka
   (a) recognised Sinhala as the only official language (b) gave equal status to Tamil and Sinhala (c) created a separate Tamil state (d) abolished Buddhism as a state religion
4. "Power-sharing helps reduce the possibility of conflict between social groups." This is a
   (a) moral reason (b) legal reason (c) prudential reason (d) religious reason
5. The system in which each organ of government checks the others is called
   (a) vertical division of power (b) coalition government (c) community government (d) checks and balances
6. Brussels was chosen as the headquarters of which organisation?
   (a) United Nations (b) European Union (c) World Trade Organisation (d) NATO
7. Reserved constituencies for weaker sections in India are an example of power-sharing among
   (a) organs of government (b) levels of government (c) social groups (d) pressure groups only
8. Explain the majoritarian measures adopted by the Sri Lankan government after independence.
9. Describe the different forms of power-sharing in modern democracies with examples.

Answers: 1. b 2. d 3. a 4. c 5. d 6. b 7. c 8. see notes 9. see notes